mein’ (The workers were driven), is how a senior RSS leader from UP described the Sangh’s involvement in the 2014 election.

The fact is, parties like the Congress simply don’t have anything remotely matching the dedicated swayamsevak cadres. The Congress’s frontal organizations like the Seva Dal have an antique look about them. Even the left has struggled to sustain its grass-roots network beyond Bengal and Kerala. Regional forces like the BSP and the Trinamool have been a shade more successful, but they, too, operate within a limited geography. To win elections, you need an organizational machine. And the RSS with its 45,000 shakhas and 5 million swayamsevaks across India provides the BJP with the feet on the ground, a cutting-edge advantage at election time.

Shah also turned his attention to the VHP which had been feeling isolated, convinced that their dream of a Ram mandir in Ayodhya would never be fulfilled. The VHP’s sants and sadhus had already endorsed Modi at the Kumbh Mela in January 2013, hoping that he would revive their dwindling fortunes. In July, just a month after taking over, Shah paid a visit to the makeshift Ram temple in Ayodhya, offering prayers for Modi’s *raj tilak* (coronation) and the Congress’s vanvas. ‘Ram and Ayodhya live in the hearts of millions of Indians. I have prayed that everyone comes together for the building of a Ram temple,’ he told the media. The VHP was enthused—finally, a BJP leader was speaking their language in unapologetic terms. A latent Hindu passion was being reawakened, as had been the case in the 1990s. Many VHP sadhus were now ready to join the 2014 campaign.

Perhaps this was easier to achieve with Modi at the helm. In the 2009 elections, the traditional Sangh Parivar workers had been disillusioned with Advani’s attempt to recast himself as a more moderate Hindutva face. Vajpayee’s inclusive politics didn’t suit the more fiery VHP–RSS rabble-rousers. Modi was different. He could excite the saffron brotherhood because he was seen as one of their own. ‘Modi may have become a national politician, but he is always a swayamsevak and pracharak first,’ is how an RSS leader described Modi’s appeal. Shah knew this, which is why it was that much easier to crack the whip and get the organization to go